

The Desire-Accessibility Paradox:

How K-Shaped Markets Are Forcing Luxury Brands to Choose Between Revenue and Desire

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Why it matters

The K-shaped economy is forcing luxury brands to rethink traditional growth models built on expanding aspirational demand. Building and protecting long-term desirability may require sacrificing short-term volume in favour of stronger pricing power, exclusivity and customer relationships.

Key takeaways

- The luxury market is increasingly polarised, with growth concentrated among high-value clients while many aspirational consumers are priced out of the category.
- Brands need to decide whether they are building visible cultural desire or deeper client relationships, rather than trying to optimise for both simultaneously.
- High prices are not a key driver of exclusivity; brands such as Brunello Cucinelli and Hermès demonstrate that disciplined pricing, scarcity and trusted relationships can create stronger long-term demand.
- Accessible entry points can broaden participation without undermining luxury positioning when they preserve the integrity of the core brand, as illustrated by Miu Miu's accessories and beauty strategy.
- Revenue can be a lagging indicator of brand health. Marketers should monitor measures of desire alongside commercial performance to identify shifts in brand momentum earlier.

- In a K-shaped market, the greatest risk may be trying to serve every luxury consumer. The strongest-performing brands make clear choices about who they serve and build their pricing, communications and distribution accordingly.

The global luxury customer base has lost [70 million people since 2022](#). The brands that kept raising prices anyway are the ones still growing. And the wealthiest clients left are starting to feel betrayed.

The Problem

For decades, luxury growth followed a simple logic: expand aspirational access, grow the customer base, scale revenues. Between 2019 and 2023, that playbook delivered [a compound annual growth rate of 5%](#). But according to [McKinsey, more than 80% of that growth came from price increases](#), not volume. The customer base was already hollowing out before anyone noticed.

The K-shaped market has made that hollowing visible. At the top, ultra-high-net-worth consumers continue spending. At the bottom, aspirational buyers have been priced out, pushed away, or simply lost interest. According to [Bain and Altagamma's 2025 Luxury Market Study](#), the global luxury customer base fell from 400 million in 2022 to 330 million in 2025, a loss of 70 million consumers in three years. The middle, where most brands positioned themselves, is disappearing.

This forces a strategic choice that the industry has avoided naming directly: do you follow the money upward and abandon the aspirational consumer entirely, or do you protect the base of desire that made luxury desirable in the first place? The brands analysed here have each answered that question differently. The results are not what most marketing playbooks would predict.

The industry is beginning to sense this. In early 2026, [Kering started reconfiguring the incentives of its brand CEOs to reward desirability over top-line growth](#), and [Lyst rebuilt its influential Index around Desire](#) as an explicit pillar. But sensing the problem is not the same as solving it. As [Business of Fashion put it](#), luxury brands now target desirability first but do not know how to measure it. This article makes two contributions to that open question. First, it quantifies the time lag between desire and revenue:

across the cases analysed here, shifts in cultural desire preceded financial results by roughly 18 to 24 months, which means desire metrics are not vanity metrics but early warning systems. Second, it shows that desire is not one market but two: the desire that indices can see, built on searches and social attention, and the desire they cannot, built on private client relationships among the wealthiest consumers. Brands are collapsing not because they chose the wrong desire economy, but because they tried to serve both with a single brand.

Methodology

This analysis examines six luxury brands selected for the strategic clarity of their response to market polarisation: Brunello Cucinelli, Bottega Veneta, Miu Miu, Gucci, Prada Group and Hermès. Each case is coded against six variables: pricing strategy, distribution, communication, target client profile, recent financial performance, and cultural desire. The last variable is the analytical core of this study. Existing industry reports measure brand health through revenue. This analysis treats desire and revenue as independent dimensions, tracking each brand's quarterly position on the [Lyst Index](#) between 2023 and 2026 against its reported financial results over the same period. Sources include group financial reports and investor communications, the Lyst Index, and reporting from Bain and Altagamma, McKinsey, Reuters and Business of Fashion. The six cases are not a random sample. They were chosen for how clearly each illustrates a distinct strategic response, and the patterns identified should be read as directional rather than statistically representative. A companion dataset coding all six cases against these variables, with sources for each entry, is available at: https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1Kvi-5aIKhiSRbnrgoqWErptFtCowWt2_WTL_SXBwDY4/edit?usp=sharing

Case Analysis

1. Brunello Cucinelli - Radical Exclusivity

Brunello Cucinelli closed 2025 with [record revenues of 1.4 billion euros, up 11.5% at constant exchange rates](#), in a market that was flat at best. The company did this without an entry-level strategy, without discounting, and without registering in the [Lyst](#)

[Index top 20](#), the industry's most cited ranking of brand heat, in any quarter analysed for this study.

That last detail matters more than it seems. Cucinelli's growth is not powered by the desire economy that indices like Lyst can measure: online searches, social mentions, viral products. Its desire lives somewhere else entirely, in client relationships, waitlists and word of mouth among ultra-high-net-worth consumers who do not express demand through search bars. The brand is proof that aspirational visibility and commercial desirability are not the same thing.

The most counterintuitive part of the Cucinelli model is its pricing discipline. While competitors' aggressive post-pandemic price hikes generated revenue growth of as much as 30% with no perceived increase in quality, Cucinelli held to a strict formula of retail prices at 7 to 8 times industrial cost. CEO Riccardo Stefanelli has been openly critical of the industry's price escalation, arguing that raising prices without a perceived increase in quality is precisely what broke customer trust across the sector. The most exclusive brand in this analysis, in other words, is also the one that refused the exclusivity-by-price shortcut.

What makes this uncomfortable for most CMOs is that Cucinelli never had to choose between revenue and desire, because it never let the two be measured by the same instrument. It optimised for a desire economy that competitors cannot see, and the revenue followed.

2. Bottega Veneta - Deliberate De-Democratisation

In January 2021, Bottega Veneta did something no major luxury brand had dared: it deleted its Instagram, Facebook and Twitter accounts, exiting the platforms the industry considers indispensable. The move was widely read as commercial suicide. Four years later, the data reads differently. In the first quarter of 2025, while [parent group Kering's revenue fell 14%, Bottega Veneta grew 4%](#), with directly operated retail sales up 7% and double-digit growth in Western Europe, North America and the Middle East. Across full-year 2025, Bottega Veneta grew 3%, closing the year with its highest-ever quarterly sales, inside a group whose flagship brand, Gucci, fell 22% over the same twelve months.

The mechanism is more sophisticated than absence. Bottega Veneta did not leave the visible desire economy; it stopped paying for it. Fan-run accounts like @newbottega now act as unofficial curators, racking up millions of impressions and turning followers into evangelists, creating a halo of exclusivity that no ad spend could replicate. The brand retained surgical exceptions where conversion justified presence, engaging via APAC-focused platforms like WeChat and collaborating with influencers on a project basis. Desire production was outsourced to the community; the brand kept control of the product and the story.

The result shows up in the desire data too: by Q4 2024, Bottega Veneta had surged to [sixth place on the Lyst Index](#), leapfrogging traditionally flashier names like Gucci, Versace and Balenciaga. A brand with no social media accounts outranking brands that post daily is the single clearest evidence in this study that feeding the visible desire economy and owning it are not the same thing.

Read against the Cucinelli case, the inversion is precise. Cucinelli proves a brand can grow inside the invisible desire economy alone. Bottega Veneta proves a brand can dominate the visible one without participating in it, letting scarcity of communication do the work that competitors buy with media budgets. Its deliberately slow revenue conversion, growing at 3% rather than Miu Miu's pace, is not underperformance. It is the cost of protecting an asset that took four years of silence to rebuild.

3. Miu Miu - Cultural Democratisation Without Price Democratisation

Miu Miu is the fastest growing major luxury brand of the past three years, and the most misread. [Retail sales grew 93% in 2024, then another 35% in 2025 against those exceptional comparatives, closing the year with a fourth quarter still up 20%](#). The lazy reading is that Miu Miu democratised luxury for Gen Z. The data says something more precise: it democratised participation while protecting price.

The mechanism is visible in the product architecture. As luxury prices escalated, small accessories became the industry's favoured entry point for priced-out consumers: [wholesale platform JOOR recorded bag charm sales rising twelvefold in the first half of 2025](#), and [stylists describe clients gravitating specifically to a Miu Miu bag charm because it delivers the brand without the full price tag](#). In parallel, 2025 brought the launch of Miutine, the brand's first fragrance with L'Oreal, opening the beauty funnel,

the other classic low-price door into a luxury house. None of this touched the core price architecture: growth remained driven by full-price sales, with no reliance on markdowns. The aspirational consumer was given a door, not a discount.

The desire data confirms the sequence this study argues for. [Lyst named Miu Miu its Brand of the Year in 2022](#), when the brand's revenues were a fraction of today's. The revenue explosion arrived in 2024, roughly two years after desire leadership was established, and Miu Miu went on to hold the top or second position of the Lyst Index through virtually every quarter of 2024 and 2025. The industry watched the revenue and called it sudden. It had been building for two years in plain sight, on an index almost nobody in finance was reading.

None of this makes Miu Miu the counterexample to exclusivity that it appears to be. It is the visible-desire mirror of Cucinelli's invisible model: one brand optimises for a desire economy that indices cannot measure, the other for the one they measure obsessively. Both refuse the trap that broke the middle of the market, converting desire into revenue faster than desire can be replenished. Whether even the best managed visible-desire strategy can outrun the churn of the attention economy is now being tested directly: growth has decelerated from 93% to 35% to 20% across three straight periods, and that test is still running.

4. Gucci / Kering - The Cost of the Middle

Every industry has one case that everyone points at, and nobody wants to study properly. In luxury, that case is Gucci.

The numbers are brutal enough to have become familiar. [From a peak of 10.49 billion euros in 2022, revenue fell to 9.87 billion in 2023, to 7.65 billion in 2024, a drop of 23% in a single year, and to roughly 5.9 billion in 2025, a decline of more than 40% from the 2022 peak](#). The usual explanations get recycled every quarter: creative fatigue, too many logo products, overexposure to the Chinese aspirational consumer. Each is true on its own terms, but together they describe symptoms rather than the mechanism.

What the desire data shows is more uncomfortable, because it comes with timestamps. Gucci sat at the top of the Lyst Index in the early 2020s, the hottest brand in the world by the metric everyone watches. By mid-2024 it had slid to tenth. By 2025

it had fallen further still. The revenue collapse that shocked the market in 2024 was not sudden at all: desire had been draining out of the brand for two years while the income statement still looked defensible, and the industry kept reading the income statement. It is worth noting that this was not an industry-wide collapse. Over the same stretch, [LVMH's fashion and leather goods division and Hermès both continued to post growth](#); the crisis was specific to a brand that had lost its footing, not to luxury as a category.

Gucci's deeper problem is that it was built to serve both desire economies at once. Its engine was aspirational: logo goods, viral moments, accessible entry categories sold at scale. Its ambition was elite: pricing and positioning alongside Hermès and Chanel. When the aspirational base was priced out after 2022, the brand discovered that two decades of visibility had bought it very little of the invisible desire that sustains a Cucinelli. The customers who could still afford it had never been given a private reason to stay.

There is a coda, and it points forward rather than back. When Demna's first runway shows for the house arrived in early 2026, Gucci returned to the [Lyst Index top five for the first time since 2022](#), with demand jumping 12% day-on-day immediately after the show. By the first quarter of 2026, Gucci's sales were still down 14% overall, though already growing in North America. It is worth noting that Q1 2026 results across the sector were also affected by a Middle East-related demand shock tied to the conflict with Iran, which hit Kering, LVMH and even the more resilient Hermès in the same quarter; that context complicates a completely clean read on Gucci's specific recovery this early, though the divergence between Gucci and the two more stable groups remained visible even within the shock. A gap between rising desire and lagging revenue is precisely the pattern this study describes. Kering's own behaviour suggests it agrees. Beyond hiring Bain and BCG to review the group brand by brand, the company used its [April 2026 Capital Markets Day to unveil ReconKering, a turnaround plan targeting more than double the group's operating margin over the medium term](#) and explicitly aimed at reducing Kering's dependence on a single house. If the pattern this study describes holds, that dependence should keep falling only as fast as Gucci's desire converts back into revenue, a process this article estimates should not complete before late 2027. Gucci is, in effect, the live experiment behind this entire thesis.

5. Prada Group - The Dual Strategy

If Gucci is the cautionary tale of this analysis, Prada Group is closer to a control experiment. It is the only company here that never had to choose between the two desire economies, because it built one vehicle for each.

The numbers behind that structure tell a story no single brand could. In 2025 the group delivered its fifth consecutive year of growth and its twentieth consecutive quarter, with [revenues reaching 5.7 billion euros, up 9%](#). Underneath that smooth surface, the two brands were living completely different years: Miu Miu grew 35%, while Prada declined 1%, only returning to growth in the fourth quarter. On paper, one brand carried the other. In strategic terms, each was simply doing its job.

Miu Miu's job is to hunt visible desire, and it does so with the aggression of a challenger brand: viral collections, cultural moments, accessible entry points, a permanent seat at the top of the [Lyst Index](#). Prada's job is to protect institutional desire, and it plays that role with deliberate restraint, holding steady in the Lyst top five while prioritising what management calls full-price, like-for-like sales over volume. When group CEO Andrea Guerra explains the results, the vocabulary is telling: he credits the cultural relevance of the brands, their ability to anticipate and interpret contemporaneity. That is desire language, sitting inside an earnings release.

A cynic would call this a portfolio effect, and every group has one. But that misses what makes the structure unusual. Kering also owns multiple brands, and it still crashed, because its portfolio was built for scale, with every house chasing the same aspirational customer that evaporated after 2022. Prada Group's two brands do not compete for the same desire. One absorbs the volatility of the attention economy; the other compounds quietly beneath it. The group result is what stability looks like when volatility is designed in, rather than avoided.

The structure now faces its real test. In December 2025 the group completed the [acquisition of Versace, a 684-million-euro revenue brand](#) that arrives with heat, heritage, and a positioning problem, and the group itself expects Versace's sales to contract in 2026 as repositioning begins. Whether the dual-desire architecture can absorb a third vehicle that currently belongs to neither desire economy will decide whether this model is a strategy others can copy, or a two-brand coincidence.

6. Hermès - Invisible Desire at Scale

Hermès sits in the same quadrant as Cucinelli, at a scale that removes any doubt about whether invisible desire can carry a large business rather than a niche one. In 2025 the house [generated 16 billion euros in revenue, up 9% at constant exchange rates, with an operating margin above 40%](#). Leather Goods, the division built around the Birkin and Kelly, grew 14.6% even as the aspirational consumer retreated across the rest of the industry.

The clearest evidence sits in what Hermès does not chase. It rarely registers in the [Lyst Index top ten](#), the ranking every other brand in this study competes for. [One 2025 industry analysis of search-driven desirability recorded Hermès's online search interest falling 8.3% year over year](#), even as independent estimates put its brand value near 33 billion dollars and its revenue kept climbing. Search falling while revenue rises, in the same year, is about as clean a confirmation as this study offers that visible desire and commercial desirability are not the same variable.

Hermès manufactures scarcity structurally rather than communicating it. Waitlists for the Birkin can run for years, production is deliberately capped below what demand would support, and marketing spend is a fraction of what its peers commit. Desire is managed through sales advisors and client history rather than campaigns built to be searched for. It is Cucinelli's model at roughly ten times the revenue, and it answers a question the Cucinelli case alone could not settle: whether the invisible-desire quadrant has a ceiling. At 16 billion euros, none has appeared yet.

The Desire-Accessibility Framework

Everything this analysis has shown can be reduced to two questions that most luxury brands never ask separately: how much desire does the brand generate, and how accessible is that desire's satisfaction? The relationship between the two, not revenue on its own, is what predicts where a brand will be in two years.

The map below plots the six cases against those two dimensions. One axis measures desire, split into its two economies: the visible kind that indices track, and the invisible kind that lives in client books. The other measures accessibility: how easily the brand lets wanting convert into owning.

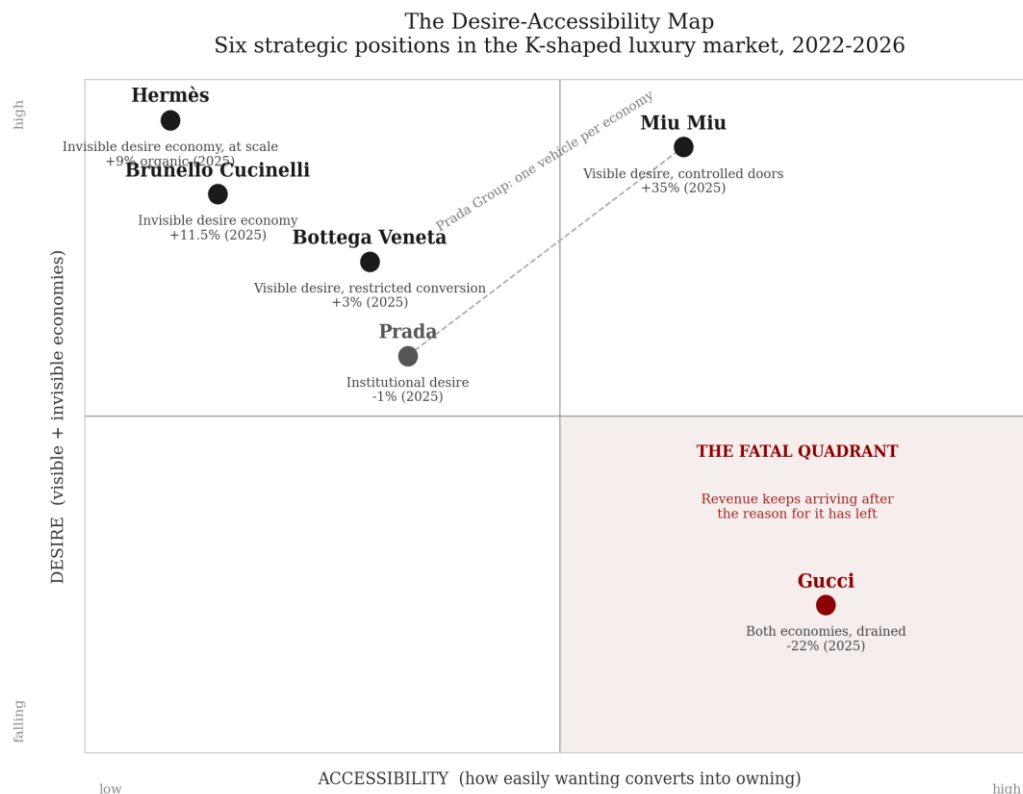


Figure 1: The Desire-Accessibility Map. Six strategic positions in the K-shaped luxury market, 2022-2026.

Read case by case, the map is just a summary. Read as a whole, it reveals the pattern this article exists to name. Hermès and Cucinelli occupy the same corner at different scale, both proving that high invisible desire can be paired with very low accessibility and still grow. Miu Miu holds high visible desire with controlled accessibility, a door but not a discount, and grows explosively. Bottega Veneta pairs high visible desire with deliberately restricted conversion and grows slowly by choice. Prada Group covers two positions with two vehicles. Every one of those positions works. Only one position on the map is fatal: high accessibility with falling desire, the quadrant where revenue keeps arriving after the reason for it has already left, and where a revenue-only dashboard tells management everything is fine. Gucci spent close to three years there before the income statement admitted it.

This is why the time lag matters. In the two clearest cases here, the signal moved roughly two years before the money. Gucci's slide down the Lyst Index began in 2022 and 2023; the revenue collapse registered in 2024. Miu Miu was named Lyst's Brand of the Year in 2022; the 93% revenue explosion arrived in 2024. Two cases do not make a statistical law, and this study does not claim one. What they establish is

direction and magnitude: desire is a leading indicator measured in years, not quarters, which means a brand that waits for revenue confirmation has already spent its response time.

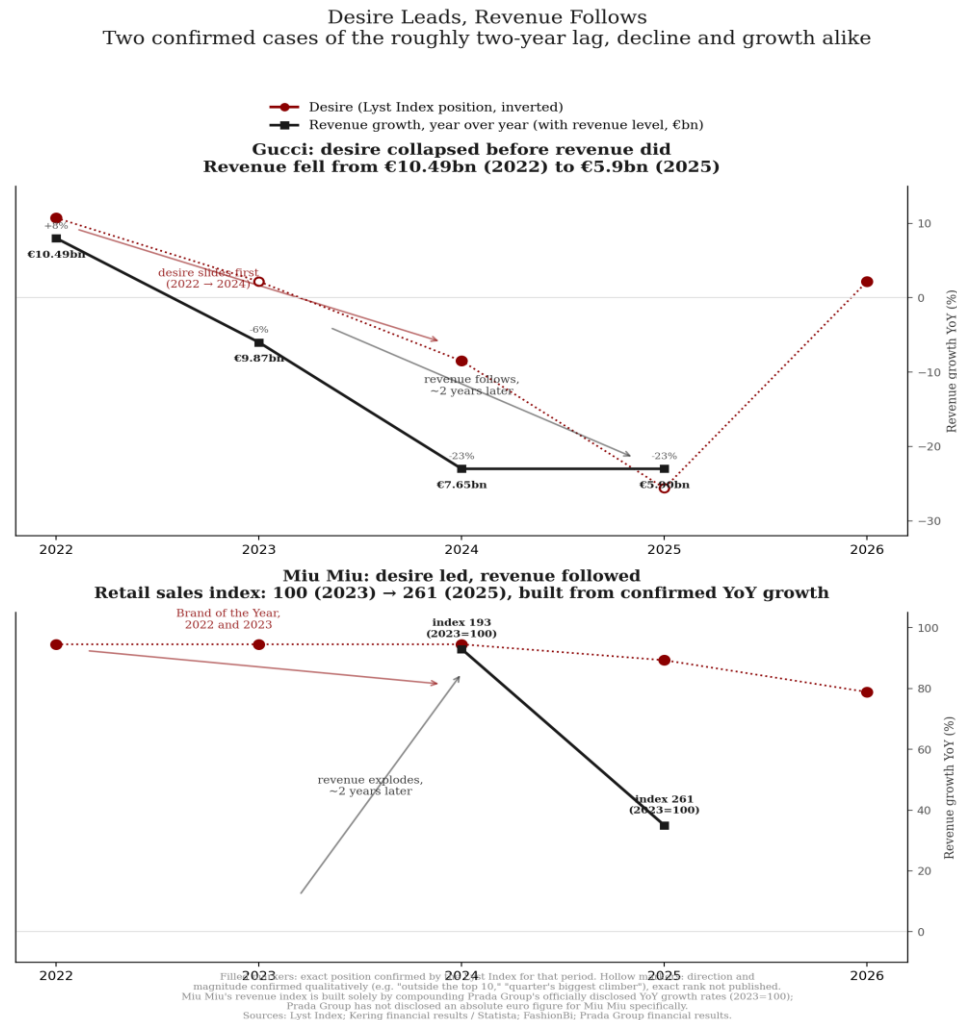


Figure 2: *Desire Leads; Revenue Follows*. Two confirmed cases of the roughly two-year lag between cultural desire and financial performance, decline and growth alike.

For a practitioner, the framework converts into a monitoring discipline rather than a formula. Visible desire is trackable today: index positions, search trends, the share of demand arriving at full price. Invisible desire has no public index, but every brand owns its proxies: waitlist depth, repeat purchase rates among top clients, the share of sales that never touches a marketing channel. The discipline is to track both separately, resist the instinct to average them into one brand-health score, and treat a divergence between desire and revenue not as noise but as the earliest information the market will ever give you. One warning follows directly from the Gucci case: the two desire

economies cannot be served by the same brand at the same time. A house must know which economy it lives in and build its accessibility around that answer.

There is a further lesson here about long-term brand building. A strong, well-known brand is not, on its own, a reliable guarantee of future growth in luxury. Gucci was arguably the most recognised name in the category at the start of this decade, and that recognition alone did not protect it once the market split. What separated the brands that held up was not the size of their heritage but whether they kept re-aligning desire and accessibility as conditions shifted under them. Heritage gives a brand its starting position. It does not run the business from there on its own; someone still has to keep adjusting the two dials this article is about.

The framework has limits worth naming. Visible desire metrics can be inflated by viral moments that never convert, and they see nothing of the wealthiest clients. The lag estimate rests on public rankings and two datable cases, and sharper instruments will refine it over time. The direction of the argument does not depend on that precision, however. The industry has spent three years learning that revenue can hide a dying brand; this framework is simply a way of refusing to be hidden from.

Conclusion

Luxury's crisis is usually described as a demand problem: 70 million consumers gone, the middle hollowed out, the aspirational buyer priced into exile. This analysis suggests the deeper problem is informational. The industry's brands did not run out of customers overnight. They ran out of desire years earlier and kept reading income statements that said otherwise.

The six cases point to one uncomfortable conclusion. The brands that thrived through the polarisation, Hermès, Cucinelli, Miu Miu, Bottega Veneta, and the Prada Group above two of them, all made the same choice in different clothing: they decided which desire economy they belonged to, built their accessibility around it, and accepted the growth rate that choice implied. The brand that collapsed, Gucci, refused to choose, and paid for it with a 23% revenue decline in 2024 that its own desire data had signalled two years earlier. In a K-shaped market, the middle is not a position. It is the absence of one.

What this means in practice differs by seat. For a CMO at an established house, the task is to pick an economy deliberately rather than let accessibility drift upward in pursuit of quarterly revenue. For a manager building a premium, not yet luxury, brand, the opportunity is to capture the aspirational consumer luxury is abandoning, without importing the identity confusion that broke Gucci. For an investor or analyst, the practical instruction is simpler still: read desire indices and waitlist proxies as leading indicators, roughly two years ahead of the numbers that move share prices, rather than as marketing colour to be skimmed past.

Kering is now paying its executives for desirability. Lyst has rebuilt its Index around desire as an explicit pillar. The industry is converging, slowly, on the idea this article has tried to make precise. What it still lacks is the discipline of measuring desire as two separate economies with a roughly two-year fuse. The brands that adopt that discipline will see their futures early. The rest will keep discovering them in the quarterly results, two years too late.

There is a test already running. Gucci's desire began recovering in early 2026, returning the brand to the Lyst Index top five for the first time since 2022, and Kering has since committed publicly, at its April 2026 Capital Markets Day, to more than doubling group operating margin over the medium term and reducing its reliance on Gucci alone. If the pattern this article describes holds, that recovery should not show up meaningfully in Gucci's own revenue before late 2027. This prediction is now dated and public, and the market will settle it one way or the other.

Sources

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A Note on Method

AI tools were used to support research, source verification, chart production and drafting. The analysis, the framework and its conclusions are the author's own.